11.2 Project charter

A project charter authorizes the project and gives the project manager the authority to spend the organization's resources on it. It normally gets written before anything else happens. Ours is reconstructed here from what was actually agreed with BBGP at kickoff on August 28, because the project document has been built in lecture order rather than project order.

Writing it down eight weeks late turned out to be more useful than writing it at the start would have been, for one reason: the project no longer matches it, and the gaps are visible.

Element	Detail
Project name	LevelSpot Smart Parking Platform, release 1
Project sponsor	Operations Director, Buffalo Bayou Garage Partners (BBGP)
Project manager	Ibra, $oftware ¢orp. Authorized to direct the assigned team, commit the approved budget, and decide technical scope within the baseline.
Charter date	August 28, 2026. Revised October 29, 2026 (see variance note below).
Business case	BBGP turns cars away at downtown garages on weekdays while its Midtown and EaDo lots sit half empty, and has no way to steer drivers between them or price for demand. Drivers circle for parking because no existing app shows whether a space is actually free. Section 1 covers why no product on the market closes both halves of that gap.
Objectives	The five business objectives in Table 2: time to parked under 4 minutes, weekday occupancy at underused lots up 15 points, fewer than 1 in 500 reservations needing a Spot Guarantee rebook, 70% of transactions digital, and the city occupancy feed live at all 23 facilities.
Scope summary	In: driver apps on iOS, Android and web; live availability; reservations with the Spot Guarantee; digital payments; the operator dashboard; the city feed; English and Spanish. Out: street meter payment, valet, EV charging payment, enforcement, and anything outside the Houston metro. Section 2.7 is authoritative.
Key deliverables	Driver applications, operator dashboard, backend and occupancy services, gate and camera integrations at 23 facilities, anonymized city occupancy feed, and operations handover with attendant training.
Milestones	M1 requirements baseline through M8 rollout complete on June 11, 2027. Table 11 carries the dates and every change to them.
Budget authority	$3,699,780 at completion, including a 15% contingency of $482,580 held centrally by finance. The PM may commit within the baseline; anything above it needs a change request signed by the sponsor.
Success criteria	All five objectives met twelve months after launch, the platform live at all 23 facilities, and BBGP staff running day-to-day operations without $oftware ¢orp involvement.
Top risks at signing	No event API at some facilities (R1, since occurred), critical path slip on the occupancy service (R6), and schedule compression against what COCOMO says this should take.
Constraints	Fixed delivery window, dependence on third party payment, mapping and gate vendors, PCI DSS, the Texas Data Privacy and Security Act, City of Houston parking ordinances, and Apple and Google store review.

Element	Detail
Assumptions	BBGP provides facility access and sets its own prices; each facility falls into one of the three counting classes in Section 3.2; mapping licensing permits facility pins and navigation handoff.
Approval	Signed by the BBGP Operations Director and $oftware ¢orp leadership, August 28, 2026. Amendment 1 signed October 15, 2026 for the surface lot scope change and the revised budget.

Table 32: LevelSpot project charter

Variance against the charter as signed

Three things have moved since August 28, and all three went through the change request route the charter sets out rather than around it.

- **Budget.** Signed at $3,508,880, now $3,699,780. The surface lot findings added a contract engineer and $44,000 of hardware. Amendment signed October 15.
- **Scope.** The charter assumed every facility could report gate events. Two open perimeter lots now ship on a capacity model instead of live counts, which is a visible reduction in what a driver gets at those two sites.
- **Pilot size.** Three garages at signing, two now. This one used a mitigation that was already written down for risk R6, so it needed no new authority, but the sponsor was told in the same week.

Milestones M6 and M8, the pilot and the rollout, are unchanged from the charter. Those are the two commitments BBGP made plans around, and holding them is why the other three moved.